

Where does the water used for AI data centers actually go?

Posted by u/nishagunazad • 0 points • 2 comments

A gripe about data centers is that they use enormous amounts of water. I know that its for cooling, but I would think there would be some form of a closed loop cycling a discrete amount of water instead of a constant draw. What am I missing?

Comments

u/Delehal • 3 points • 2025-08-15 08:49 UTC

Most of the water is used for evaporative cooling. A closed loop would not be as efficient; the core step in evaporative cooling is allowing the heated water to escape, so that it takes the heat with it.

The evaporated water isn't destroyed. It goes through a natural water cycle, and it can be gathered again, treated and purified, and used once more. People do have concerns, though, because we also need that water for other things like agriculture or drinking it, and although there is a lot of water around, most of it is not in a drinkable state at any given moment.

u/stupidfock • 2 points • 2025-08-15 08:33 UTC

Closed loop is inefficient, most of them use evaporative cooling. So it literally just evaporates away and the water cycle continues as usual. It's only really a problem in areas prone to droughts